

THE UPPER VALLEY RETREAT

4 Days · Paro

A short, contemplative retreat lived entirely in the upper Paro Valley — staying in one place, moving at the pace of the mountains. A blessing ceremony at a 15th-century temple. Prayer flags printed by hand. The climb to the Tiger's Nest. Dinner cooked over a mud stove in a home that has stood for five hundred years. Meditation among fortress ruins. A sand mandala laid grain by grain. An evening with a Bhutanese astrologer reading your chart by firelight. The pace is the point.

Day 1 | Arrival — Blessing, Prayer Flags, Astrology

Arrive into the Paro Valley. A private blessing ceremony at a centuries-old chorten-temple, butter lamps offered in its ancient tantric interior. Afternoon: print your own prayer flags using hand-carved wooden blocks in a tradition unchanged for centuries. Lunch at a farmhouse. Evening: gather around a bonfire with a Bhutanese astrologer for a personal chart reading — bring your birth date, time, and place.

Day 2 | Tiger's Nest and the Five-Hundred-Year Kitchen

Morning hike to the Tiger's Nest through blue pine forest — 2 to 3 hours up. Light butter lamps inside before descending. As the afternoon turns, arrive at a five-hundred-year-old heritage home converted into a private museum. Sound healing on the grounds. When the session ends, move inside to the original mud stove, where the woman of the house cooks dinner the way it has been cooked in this kitchen for generations.

Day 3 | Fortress Ruins, Sand Mandala, Leisure

Morning meditation among the ruins of a four-hundred-year-old fortress — the walls still standing, the silence uninterrupted. Return for a sand mandala session with a trained practitioner: coloured sand laid grain by grain into sacred geometry. Farm lunch from the garden. Afternoon and evening at leisure — optional yoga or meditation at a nearby monastery.

Day 4 | Departure

After breakfast, transfer to the airport for your onward journey.